War world order still in search of an equilibrium, a strong relationship with Russia strengthens India's strategic autonomy. The economic and military rise of China raises the prospect of a US–China bipolarity dominating the world order in the foreseeable future. India's policymakers and the current Russian leadership share an interest in discouraging this trend.

The evolution of India–Russia relations (and India–USSR relations, from which they flow) from the early days of the Cold War until the present can be broadly classified into three phases. The first phase was during the Cold War Soviet era. The second was in the post-Soviet decade of the 1990s. The third phase took shape since 2000, with President Putin at the helm in Moscow. As it adjusts to new developments in global geopolitics, the relationship is now entering a qualitatively different fourth phase. The China factor has influenced the quality of relations, in varying degrees, in all the phases so far. It will be of even greater importance in the fourth phase.

From India–USSR to India–Russia relations

The foundations of India–USSR relations were laid in the post-Stalin period of the Cold War. Soviet leaders Nikita Khrushchev and Nikolai Bulganin visited India in November–December 1955 and declared support for the Indian position on Jammu and Kashmir and Goa (then still in Portuguese possession). Their articulations were matched by concrete actions in succeeding years, through the USSR's six vetoes in the UN Security Council on matters of core interest to India, in 1957 and 1962 on Jammu and Kashmir, in 1961 on Indian troops liberating Goa, and thrice in December 1971